

U.S. Beginnings: key facts

Unit 1 study guide • Short version

Review: Colonies, p. 1 • Revolution, pp. 2-3 • Founding and government, pp. 4-7 • Parties, p. 8 • Writing, p. 9 • Practice, p. 10 • Sources, p. 11

Pilgrims and Puritans

Pilgrims: Religious Separatists left the Church of England. They settled Plymouth in **1620**. William Bradford was a key leader.

Puritans: Wanted to reform the Church of England. They settled Massachusetts Bay, mainly from **1630**. John Winthrop was a key leader.

Both: Sought freedom for their own religion. Neither gave everyone equal religious or voting rights.

Mayflower Compact, 1620

An agreement to form a government and obey laws for the common good. Settlers needed rules because they landed outside their planned settlement area.

Why it matters: Early self-government based on agreement and consent. It was signed by men and kept loyalty to England; it was not independence or full democracy.

Words to know: Civil body politic = organized political community. Covenant = agreement. Ordinances = laws. General good = common welfare.

The thirteen colonies

Feature	New England	Middle	Southern
Colonies	Massachusetts, New Hampshire, Rhode Island, Connecticut	New York, New Jersey, Pennsylvania, Delaware	Maryland, Virginia, North Carolina, South Carolina, Georgia
Land and climate	Rocky soil; cold; short growing season	Fertile soil; moderate climate; rivers and ports	Long growing season; fertile areas; rivers
Main work	Small farms, fishing, shipbuilding, trade	Grain farming, trade, crafts	Cash crops: tobacco, rice, indigo; plantations and small farms
Society	Many compact towns; Puritan influence; local schools	More religious and cultural diversity; Quaker influence in Pennsylvania	More spread-out settlements; wealthy plantation owners held power

Comparisons to remember

Shared: British rule, farming, Atlantic trade, local government, and slavery. Slavery existed in all three regions, but was most central to Southern plantation farming.

Labor: Indentured servants worked for a set term. Enslaved people were treated as property, usually for life; their children could also be enslaved.

Why choose the Middle colonies? Good farmland, port jobs, religious tolerance, and diverse communities.

One American society by 1775? Shared protests built unity, but regional differences and Patriot-Loyalist divisions remained.

Limits: Voting rights were restricted. Colonization displaced Native peoples. Maine belonged to Massachusetts; Vermont was not one of the thirteen colonies.

Sources: Class sheets IMG_7201, IMG_7207-7209; [1-2].

2. Road to Revolution

British control led to growing resistance

Ideas behind resistance

Enlightenment: Reason and natural rights. Locke stressed rights and consent; Montesquieu supported dividing government power.

Great Awakening: Religious revivals in the 1730s-1740s stressed personal faith and challenged church leaders. Key figures: Jonathan Edwards and George Whitefield.

Both encouraged questioning authority: one through reason, the other through religion.

Key events

Date / event	What happened and why it mattered
1754-1763: French and Indian War	Britain defeated France. War debt and defense costs led Britain to seek more money from the colonies.
1763: Proclamation	Limited settlement west of the Appalachians, angering settlers.
1764: Sugar Act	Changed import duties and tightened collection. Merchants opposed the taxes and enforcement.
1765: Stamp Act	Taxed printed and legal papers. Protests, boycotts, and the Stamp Act Congress united colonists.
1766: Declaratory Act	Britain repealed the Stamp Act but claimed full power to make colonial laws.
1767: Townshend duties	Import taxes on glass, paper, paint, lead, and tea led to more boycotts.
1770: Boston Massacre	British soldiers killed five colonists. Patriot accounts increased anger at Britain.
1772-1773: Committees of correspondence	Shared news and helped colonies organize resistance.
1773: Tea Act / Boston Tea Party	The law favored the East India Company and kept the tea duty. Protesters dumped tea into Boston Harbor.
1774: Intolerable Acts	Punished Massachusetts, closed Boston's port, and limited self-government. Other colonies rallied to help.
1774: First Continental Congress	Coordinated resistance and a boycott. It did not declare independence.
1775: Lexington and Concord	Fighting began on April 19.
1775: Second Continental Congress	Directed the war, created the Continental Army, and chose Washington to lead it.
1776: Common Sense	Thomas Paine argued for independence and against monarchy.
July 4, 1776: Declaration	Congress declared independence and explained why.

No taxation without representation: Colonists had no elected members in Parliament and argued that taxes needed their consent.

Resistance methods: Boycotts hurt British trade; the Sons of Liberty organized protests; committees shared information.

Tea Act correction: It did not create a new tea tax. Even cheaper tea could be opposed because the existing tax and company privileges remained.

Cause chain: War debt → taxes and tighter control → protest → punishment → war → independence.

Sources: Class sheets IMG_7205-7206; [3-5].

3. The American Revolution

Know the outcome and why it mattered

Event	Key fact
Lexington and Concord, 1775	First fighting of the war. Minutemen were militia ready to act quickly.
Bunker Hill, 1775	Britain won the position but lost many soldiers. Americans showed they could fight effectively. Much fighting was on Breed's Hill.
Declaration, 1776	Made independence the official goal. Fighting had already started.
Trenton and Princeton, 1776-1777	Washington's victories raised American morale.
Saratoga, 1777	Major American victory that helped secure the French alliance.
Valley Forge, 1777-1778	The army faced shortages and disease; training improved its strength.
French alliance, 1778	France formally joined the U.S. cause, providing money, supplies, troops, and ships. Some French aid had begun earlier.
Yorktown, 1781	American and French forces trapped Cornwallis. The French fleet blocked rescue or escape by sea.
Treaty of Paris, 1783	Britain recognized U.S. independence. The U.S. boundary extended west to the Mississippi.

Strengths and weaknesses

Side	Strengths	Weaknesses
Americans	Washington; local knowledge; strong motivation; French aid	Shortages of money and supplies; uneven training; weak navy; divided loyalties
British	Trained army; powerful navy; more money; Loyalist help	Long supply routes across the Atlantic; huge area to control; costly war

Why America won: Washington kept an army fighting. Britain's distance made the war harder to manage. French troops and ships helped turn resistance into victory.

Supply correction: Local farms did not guarantee enough food. Buying and moving supplies remained difficult.

Government correction: Congress existed, but had weak funding and limited power to enforce decisions.

People and loyalties

Patriots: Wanted independence. **Loyalists:** Supported Britain. Others stayed neutral.

Native nations sought to protect their own interests and lands. Black people served on both sides, often seeking freedom. Not all colonists or Britons agreed about the war.

Four dates to memorize

1775 = fighting starts. 1777 = Saratoga. 1781 = Yorktown. 1783 = peace.

Do not mix up the Treaties of Paris: **1763** ended the French and Indian War; **1783** ended the American Revolutionary War.

Sources: Class sheets IMG_7203-7204; [3, 6-7].

4. Founding the nation

Declaration, Articles, and western lands

Declaration of Independence, 1776

Main writer: Thomas Jefferson. **Adopted by:** Second Continental Congress, July 4.

Main argument: People have rights. Government needs their consent and must protect those rights. Repeated abuse can justify replacing it.

Named rights: Life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.

Complaints against the king: Taxes without consent, limits on self-government, military force, and interference with laws and courts.

Purpose: Explain and announce independence to colonists, Britain, and the world.

Limit: Equality was an ideal, not reality. Slavery and unequal rights continued.

Articles of Confederation

The first U.S. national constitution. Adopted in **1777**, fully approved in **1781**, replaced in **1789**. States kept most power because Americans feared another strong ruler.

Feature	Result
One-house Congress; one vote per state	All states had equal votes, regardless of size.
Congress could not tax directly	It relied on states for money and struggled to pay debts.
No general power over trade	States created conflicting trade rules.
No separate executive; no broad federal court system	National decisions were hard to carry out.
Nine states for major decisions; all thirteen for changes	Action and reform were difficult.

Powers and successes: Congress could make treaties, conduct war, borrow money, and pass land laws. The Articles were weak, not useless.

Shays' Rebellion, 1786-1787: Massachusetts farmers protested debts, taxes, and loss of property. The unrest increased support for a stronger national government.

Two land laws

Law	Key facts
Land Ordinance of 1785	Surveyed and sold western land. Townships were 6 × 6 miles, with 36 sections. Section 16 supported schools.
Northwest Ordinance of 1787	Set rules for territorial government and equal statehood, generally at 60,000 free inhabitants. Protected some rights and banned slavery in the territory, but required returning fugitives from slavery.

Remember: 1785 = survey and sell. 1787 = govern and become states. Both were achievements under the Articles.

Northwest Territory: North of the Ohio River and east of the Mississippi, not today's Pacific Northwest. U.S. expansion displaced Native peoples.

Sources: Class sheets IMG_7201-7202; [8-11].

5. Constitution and government

Divide power and limit its use

Convention and compromises

Philadelphia, 1787: Delegates replaced the Articles. Washington led the Convention; Madison helped plan the Constitution.

Plan / compromise	Main idea
Virginia Plan	Strong national government; two houses; representation based on population or contribution. Favored large states.
New Jersey Plan	One house with equal state votes. Favored small states.
Great Compromise	Two-house Congress: House seats based on population; Senate has two members per state.
Three-Fifths Compromise	Counted three-fifths of enslaved people for House representation and direct taxes. It gave enslaved people no votes.

Federalists: Supported approving the Constitution. **Anti-Federalists:** Feared too much national power and wanted stronger rights protections.

Dates: Written **1787**; required approval **1788**; government began **1789**; Bill of Rights **1791**.

Three branches

Branch	Who?	Main job
Legislative: Article I	Congress: House and Senate	Makes laws; taxes and spends; declares war.
Executive: Article II	President and executive officials	Enforces laws; commands the military; can veto bills.
Judicial: Article III	Supreme Court and lower federal courts	Interprets laws; can rule government actions unconstitutional.

Government principles

Popular sovereignty: Power comes from the people.

Republic: People choose representatives to govern.

Limited government: Government must obey the law and Constitution.

Separation of powers: Branches have different jobs.

Checks and balances: Each branch can limit the others.

Federalism: Power is divided between national and state governments. Some powers, such as taxation, are shared.

Checks to know:

- President **veto**es a bill → Congress can override with **two-thirds of each house**.
- President nominates federal judges → Senate confirms them.
- Courts can strike down unconstitutional laws or actions.
- House **impeaches**: brings charges. Senate tries the case; a **two-thirds vote of senators present** can convict and remove.
- President negotiates treaties → two-thirds of senators present must agree to ratification.

Correct the notes: Executive = enforce, not just propose. Impeach = charge, not convict. Popular sovereignty = power from people, not separate branches.

Sources: Class sheet IMG_7200 and new government sheet; [12-13].

6. The Bill of Rights

First ten amendments • Ratified in 1791

No.	Key protection
1	Religion, speech, press, peaceful assembly, petition. Religion includes no government-established religion and free exercise of religion.
2	Right to keep and bear arms.
3	No quartering soldiers in homes during peacetime without the owner's consent. In wartime, it must follow law.
4	No unreasonable searches or seizures. Warrants need probable cause and must state the place and people or things involved.
5	Grand jury; no double jeopardy or forced self-incrimination; due process; just compensation for property taken for public use.
6	Speedy, public criminal trial; impartial jury; notice of charges; lawyer; rights involving witnesses.
7	Jury trial in qualifying federal civil cases. The text says disputes above \$20.
8	No excessive bail or fines; no cruel and unusual punishment.
9	People keep other rights even if the Constitution does not list them.
10	Powers not given to the national government or forbidden to states stay with states or the people.

Fifth Amendment: five parts

1. Grand jury: Decides whether there is enough basis for a serious federal charge. It does not decide guilt. The text includes military exceptions.

2. Double jeopardy: Generally bars another criminal prosecution or punishment for the same offense by the same government after acquittal or conviction.

3. Self-incrimination: Government cannot force you to give testimony against yourself in a criminal case.

4. Due process: Government must use lawful, fair procedures before taking life, liberty, or property.

5. Taking property: Government must pay just compensation when taking private property for public use.

Sixth Amendment: trial rights

The worksheet's four answers: **speedy and public trial; impartial jury; know the charges; lawyer.**

Also know: the right to question witnesses against you and use the court's power to bring witnesses who help your defense.

Grand jury = whether to charge. Trial jury = whether guilty.

Quick differences

4 = searches. 5 = criminal protections and property. 6 = criminal trial. 7 = civil jury. 8 = bail, fines, punishment. 9 = rights. 10 = powers.

The Bill of Rights first limited the federal government. Many protections later applied to states through the Fourteenth Amendment. Rights have limits; for example, not every lawful search needs a warrant.

Sources: New Bill of Rights sheet; [14-15].

7. Six legal terms

Use these short definitions on the worksheet

Quartering of troops - Amendment 3

Meaning: Housing soldiers.

Rule: Peacetime quartering in a home needs the owner's consent. Wartime quartering must follow law.

Example: Officials cannot force a homeowner to house soldiers in peacetime without consent.

Due process - Amendment 5

Meaning: Government must follow lawful, fair procedures before taking life, liberty, or property.

Example: A person facing punishment must have a fair chance to respond.

Remember: It applies beyond criminal trials. The Fourteenth Amendment also requires due process from states.

Self-incrimination - Amendment 5

Meaning: Giving testimony that could help prove your own criminal guilt.

Rule: You cannot be forced to give such testimony against yourself.

Remember: This is not a right to refuse every question or every kind of evidence.

Double jeopardy - Amendment 5

Meaning: Being put in criminal jeopardy twice for the same offense.

Example: After acquittal, the same government cannot simply try you again for that offense because it dislikes the verdict.

Correction: It does not mean “you cannot be sued twice.” Civil lawsuits are different. Some retrials are allowed.

Eminent domain - Amendment 5

Meaning: Government's power to take private property for public use.

Rule: It must pay just compensation.

Example: Taking land for a public road and fairly paying its owner.

Correction: The Constitution does not ban all government takings.

Bail - Amendment 8

Meaning: Money or security used for release before trial to help ensure a person returns to court.

Rule: Bail cannot be excessive. Release can also have other conditions.

Correction: Bail is not a fine or proof of guilt. The amendment does not guarantee release in every case.

Other worksheet wording to fix

“**Protest**” → peaceful assembly. “**Ask for change**” → petition.

“**Self-defense**” → the Second Amendment's right is to keep and bear arms.

“**Protection from private property**” → protection from unreasonable searches and seizures.

Ninth = unlisted rights. Tenth = reserved powers.

Sources: New vocabulary and Bill of Rights sheets; [14-16].

8. Political parties

Keep the historical and modern groups separate

Early parties: 1790s

Topic	Federalist Party	Democratic-Republicans
Leaders	Hamilton, Adams	Jefferson, Madison
Government	Stronger national government	More state power; limits on national power
Economy	Business, trade, manufacturing, national bank	Farming; distrust of concentrated financial power
Main support	Merchants and commercial interests, especially in the Northeast	Farmers and many Southern and Western voters
Constitution	Broad use of implied powers	Stricter reading of federal powers
Political outlook	More trust in established leaders	More trust in ordinary farmers; many people still lacked political rights
Foreign ties	Often favored Britain	Often favored France

Bank example: Hamilton said a national bank helped carry out federal financial powers. Jefferson argued that the Constitution did not give the government that power.

Date correction: The sheet says “1788,” but organized party rivalry developed in the **1790s**. The **1787-1788** debate was Federalists versus Anti-Federalists over approving the Constitution.

Modern parties: your worksheet's broad comparison

Democrats	Republicans
More active national government	More limits on federal economic involvement
More business regulation	Less business regulation
Pro-labor; worker and union protections	Pro-business; fewer burdens on business
Linked to “loose” interpretation on the sheet	Linked to “strict” interpretation on the sheet

These are broad class labels, not rules for every person or issue. Both parties support strong federal action in some areas. Constitutional interpretation does not fit a simple party rule.

Strict interpretation: Read federal powers narrowly. **Loose interpretation:** Allow broader implied powers, while still needing a constitutional basis.

Do not equate them: Neither early party is simply the same as a modern party.

Political spectrum, left to right

Radical → Liberal → Moderate → Conservative → Reactionary

Radical: Wants deep change. **Liberal:** Favors reform. **Moderate:** Near the center. **Conservative:** Values tradition and slower change. **Reactionary:** Wants to restore an earlier order.

These labels depend on the time and issue. Radical does not automatically mean violent.

Sources: New parties sheet; [17-18]. Modern labor/regulation examples also appear in the 2024 party platforms listed on p. 11.

9. Seven writing prompts

Short outlines for the teacher's half-page responses

Use **claim** → **two or three facts** → **why they matter**. Turn these outlines into your own sentences.

1. What was the Mayflower Compact? Why was it important?

Claim: A 1620 agreement to form a government and obey laws for the common good.

Evidence: Signers agreed to shared rules; government rested on their agreement.

Meaning: Early self-government and consent. It still recognized the king and did not give everyone a vote.

2. How were the three colonial regions alike and different?

Alike: British rule, farming, trade, slavery, and local government.

Different: New England: rocky land, fishing and trade. Middle: fertile grain farms and diverse communities. South: long growing season, cash crops, and plantations.

Meaning: Geography shaped work and settlement.

3. Why would immigrants choose the Middle colonies?

Reasons: Fertile farmland; jobs in ports and crafts; greater religious tolerance; communities of different backgrounds.

Example: Pennsylvania's Quaker influence encouraged tolerance.

Limit: This describes voluntary immigrants. Enslaved people did not choose where to settle.

4. How did the Declaration lay a foundation for government?

Claim: It tied government's power to rights and the people's consent.

Evidence: Life, liberty, pursuit of happiness; government protects rights; people may replace a repeatedly abusive government.

Meaning: Leaders serve the people. The Constitution later created the government structure.

5. Was the government under the Articles effective?

Claim: It had useful successes but was too weak for lasting national government.

Success: Land laws organized settlement and statehood.

Weaknesses: No direct taxing power meant little reliable money; weak trade powers caused conflicts; unanimous approval made changes hard.

Result: Shays' Rebellion added pressure for reform.

6. How does the Constitution show separation of powers?

Claim: It divides basic jobs among three branches.

Evidence: Congress makes laws; the president enforces them; courts interpret them.

Meaning: No branch controls every step. Checks add limits: veto and override; nomination and Senate confirmation.

Distinction: Federalism divides national and state power, not the three branches.

7. Pick an amendment and explain why it matters to democracy.

Example: First Amendment. Name religion, speech, press, peaceful assembly, and petition.

Explain: People can criticize leaders, get information, organize, and seek change. These rights help voters hold government accountable.

Finish: Democracy needs free debate as well as elections.

Sources: Seven prompts from IMG_7201, shortened here; facts and sources on pp. 1-8.

10. Quick practice

Cover the answers first

1. How did Pilgrims and Puritans differ? Why did the Mayflower Compact matter?
2. Give one geography-to-economy link for each colonial region.
3. Explain the chain from the French and Indian War to independence.
4. What did the First and Second Continental Congresses do?
5. Why did Saratoga, Yorktown, and the Treaty of Paris matter?
6. Name the Articles' main weakness and one success. Distinguish the two land ordinances.
7. What did the Great Compromise and Three-Fifths Compromise decide?
8. Distinguish popular sovereignty, separation of powers, checks and balances, and federalism. Does impeachment mean removal?
9. Name the First Amendment's five freedoms and Fifth Amendment's five protections. What is the difference between the Sixth and Seventh?
10. Define quartering, due process, self-incrimination, double jeopardy, eminent domain, and bail. Name each amendment.
11. Distinguish the Ninth and Tenth Amendments. Name all three Eighth Amendment protections.
12. Compare Hamilton's and Jefferson's parties. Then give two modern-party differences from the worksheet and name the five spectrum labels in order.

Answers

1. Pilgrims separated from the Church of England; Puritans wanted reform. The Compact created agreed rules and showed early self-government.
2. New England: rocky soil encouraged fishing/trade. Middle: fertile land supported grain. South: long growing season supported cash crops.
3. British war debt → taxes and tighter control → colonial protests → British punishment → war → independence.
4. First: resistance and boycott, 1774. Second: directed war from 1775 and adopted independence in 1776.
5. Saratoga helped secure French alliance; Yorktown brought a major British surrender; the 1783 treaty recognized U.S. independence.
6. No direct taxes meant unreliable funds. Land laws were a success: 1785 surveyed/sold land; 1787 set territorial government and statehood rules.
7. Great: population-based House, equal-state Senate. Three-Fifths: counted part of the enslaved population for representation and direct taxes; gave no votes.
8. Power from people; separate branch jobs; branches limit each other; national/state power division. Impeachment is House charges, not removal; Senate conviction removes.
9. First: religion, speech, press, assembly, petition. Fifth: grand jury, double jeopardy, self-incrimination, due process, just compensation. Sixth: criminal trial. Seventh: qualifying civil jury trial.
10. Housing soldiers (3); fair legal process (5); testimony against oneself (5); repeated criminal jeopardy for the same offense (5); public taking of property with just compensation (5); security for release and return to court (8). See p. 7 for limits.
11. Ninth: rights not listed. Tenth: powers reserved. Eighth: no excessive bail, excessive fines, or cruel and unusual punishment.
12. Hamilton: Federalist, stronger national power, business/bank, broad interpretation. Jefferson: Democratic-Republican, states/farmers, strict interpretation. Modern sheet: Democrats more regulation/pro-labor; Republicans less regulation/pro-business. Radical → Liberal → Moderate → Conservative → Reactionary.

These are original review questions, not the teacher's test.

11. Sources

Class sheets and links used for this guide

Class material: IMG_7200-7209 and the four September 30 screenshots: legal terms, Bill of Rights, political parties, and U.S. government. The short guide keeps their main topics and corrects inaccurate notes. The seven writing prompts are shortened on p. 9.

Settlement, Revolution, and founding

- [1] Plimoth Patuxet: [Mayflower Compact](#); National Park Service: [Puritans](#).
- [2] Library of Congress: [Colonial geography](#); OpenStax: [Restoration colonies](#).
- [3] National Park Service: [Revolution timeline](#).
- [4] Office of the Historian: [Parliamentary taxation](#); National Park Service: [Boston Tea Party](#).
- [5] Library of Congress: [Religion in eighteenth-century America](#); [Revolution of the Mind](#).
- [6] Office of the Historian: [French alliance](#); National Archives: [Treaty of Paris](#).
- [7] National Park Service: [Valley Forge](#); Independence Hall Association: [Military strengths and weaknesses](#).
- [8] National Archives: [Declaration of Independence](#).
- [9] National Archives: [Articles of Confederation](#).
- [10] Mount Vernon: [Shays' Rebellion](#).
- [11] National Archives: [Land Ordinance of 1785](#); [Northwest Ordinance](#).

Government, rights, and parties

- [12] National Archives: [Constitution](#); U.S. Senate: [Virginia Plan](#).
- [13] U.S. Courts: [Court role and structure](#); National Archives: [Creating the Constitution](#).
- [14] National Archives: [Bill of Rights text](#).
- [15] Congress: [Applying the Bill of Rights to states](#).
- [16] Cornell Law School: [Due process](#), [self-incrimination](#), [double jeopardy](#), [eminent domain](#), [bail](#).
- [17] Library of Congress: [Early parties](#); Stanford Encyclopedia: [Conservatism](#), [liberalism](#).
- [18] Primary party documents: [2024 Democratic platform](#); [2024 Republican platform](#). These give dated examples, not fixed rules for every party member.

Sources: Research carried over from the full guide; consulted September 23 and 30, 2026.